the tradition is that worship is only done once a year. On the issue of daily worship at the Shringar Gauri temple, no one has taken the opinion of the Vyas family, the priests of the temple. This matter seems to be sponsored by outside elements." The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) and Shiv Sena, one finds, are already running a 'Shringar Gauri Mukti Andolan'.

Gyanvapi's imam, Maulana Abdul Batin Noomani, finds it strange that it is the worship of Shringar Gauri that has stirred up this hornet's nest. Even though AIM's Yaseen says that the annual worship of the goddess has been an age-old practice, Noomani makes the case that Hindus themselves are divided on where the Shringar Gauri shrine should be ideally located. "Their own *mahants* say the shrine isn't here, it's somewhere else. Wherever Shringar Gauri may be, the masjid has nothing to do with it." Surprisingly, Noomani thinks of the court-mandated survey as a silver lining: "It isn't wrong. We have always welcomed it. Everyone will get to know the truth."

Though the AIM had taken a stand—that there will be no videography inside the masjid or its cellars—the Varanasi court ordered a complete resumption of the survey on May 12. AIM also wanted the "biased" advocate commissioner Ajay Kumar Mishra replaced, but Judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar instead expanded his team. On the three days that Mishra conducted his survey (May 14-16), imam Noomani says he was struck by how often findings that ought to have been confidential were being leaked. "*Yeh mil gaya, woh mil gaya* (We found this. We found that). What right do you have to say all this to the media? You are only spreading falsehoods in the minds of the people. This sort of behaviour ought to be punished." Mishra seemed to find his comeuppance on May 17, when Justice Diwakar relinquished him of his duties after finding he had hired his own cameraman during the survey.

Jitendra Singh Bisen is an outsider in Banaras. Representing his Delhi-based niece, Rakhi Singh, one of the five Shringar Gauri plaintiffs, it took Bisen only a few hours to call a press conference after it was rumoured that a *linga*-like structure had been found in Gyanvapi. President of the Vishwa Vedic Sanatan Sangh, an organisation headquartered in UP's Gonda district, Bisen said, "I would like to appeal to the nation...do not let your emotions get the better of you. Yes, a *shivalinga* has been found in Gyanvapi, but please act with patience and discretion. Ours is a constitutional fight."

In its 2019 Ayodhya verdict, the SC upheld the 1991 Act saying that the religious character of all places of worship be maintained as on Aug. 15, 1947. Any move by the Modi govt to amend the Act will be challenged in the apex court

Bisen seemed to want to make clear that the fight would not be long when his organisation was involved: "We didn't file these cases thinking they will then drag on for 500 years. No matter where we file a case—Mathura, Kashi, Qutab Minar, Taj Mahal—you will see that we get results fast. These are transformations we'll see within our lifetimes."

Given the frequency with which lawsuits are disturbing the peace of our monuments and places of worship, Bisen's threat should not be taken lightly. Especially with Alok Kumar, VHP international working president, already declaring that the Places of Worship Act doesn't apply to the "Gyanvapi Mandir". Clearly, Kashi is likely to be a new flashpoint. Having heard news of the '*shivalinga* discovery', Sunil Ambekar, an Akhil Bharatiya Prachar Pramukh of the RSS, said, "You cannot suppress history for long. This is the right time to bring all such evidence in front of our people."

While the Gyanvapi case has all the makings of another mandir vs. masjid battle as in Ayodhya, there are significant differences. For one, to appropriate the site the BJP would have to amend the 1991 Places of Worship of Act by using its brute majority in Parliament to remove Section 3 of the Act, which prohibits individuals and groups of people from converting a place of worship of any religious denomination, and Section 4, which declares that a place of worship's religious character "shall continue to be the same" as it was on August 15, 1947.

Since the Supreme Court had already upheld the 1991 Act in its 2019 Ayodhya verdict and recognised that the law as it stands secures the fundamental values of the Constitution, any such move by the ruling dispensation is bound to be challenged in the nation's highest court.

BJP leaders in Banaras remain circumspect. Daya Shankar Mishra, the recently elected MLA from Varanasi (South), said: "Both sides will respect the court's decision. This is just a survey being conducted. We really should not think of bleak future possibilities. Banaras is a city of understanding." When it comes to matters of peace, Congress leader Gaurav Kapoor finds common ground with Mishra: "Varanasi is very much a land of entrepreneurs and we like to focus on that rather than anything else. 'What did Aurangzeb do? What did Babur do?' This is just a hundred per cent political propaganda. Wouldn't it be nice if we stopped to worry about the economy for once?"

It would have been, but the mandir-masjid debate has most often precluded all other thought. ■

–with Ashish Misra